Dire Beginnings

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Intro

Dire Beginnings is a cooperative dungeon crawler for 1 to 4 players, set in the grim fantasy universe of Soulless Vessel.

You and your party will guide a group of heroes through dangerous quests, desperate battles, and cursed places where every decision can shape the fate of the realm. Across your campaign, you will face treacherous dungeons, uncover dark secrets, improve your heroes, and eventually confront a powerful villain at the heart of the unfolding catastrophe.

Each adventure is part of a larger journey. As you finish campaigns, you will gain access to new heroes and gameplay benefits. The game is designed to challenge you further and further as your party grows stronger, pushing you to adapt your tactics, refine your builds, and survive against increasingly dangerous threats.

Dire Beginnings is currently in an Early Access playtesting stage. Rules, balance, components, and content may still change based on testing and community feedback.

If you have thoughts, questions, or feedback, please share them in the Soulless Vessel community Discord. Your input helps shape the game.

Components

The game consists of the following components.

Ability Cards

Ability cards are learned by the various heroes to increase their roster of strategic options across a campaign. They are actively used to perform epic feats. Each ability belongs to a specific category:

Arcane - These are magical abilities that often manipulate the battlefield in unique ways. Most arcane abilities are not limited by range of line of sight and can target any model on the board.

Elementalism - Magical abilities that belong to one of the four main elements, earth, water, fire and air. They can create supportive or offensive effects.

Dark Arts - These are often devastating abilities that come with great power, but usually at a great cost as well.

Divine - Divine abilities are typically of a supportive or healing nature, benefitting the party.

Combat - These abilities help a hero execute great feats of combat, often favoring specific weapon loadouts depending on the card.

Tactics - These cards provide strategic benefits or support other party members in mundane but useful ways.

Survival - Abilities of this nature can help a hero explore a dungeon more effectively, produce resources or other smaller beneficial effects. Survival abilities are cheaper to learn than other abilities.

Defensive - Abilities of this type can help a hero to bolster their defenses, mitigating damage, but they can also allow them to protect their party members from incoming attacks.

Item Cards

The various item cards represent weapons, armor, accessories and consumables. The party can buy or find them to equip heroes for improved combat efficiency.

Item Affix Cards

Item affix cards are enchantments that can be attached to items to give them new powers. They stay with the item they are attached to.

Hero Reference Cards

Each class is represented by a hero card which shows basic stats (like health, stamina and speed), the ability card limits and a unique passive ability.

Campaign Quests

There are 23 unique campaign quests that represent bespoke challenges and achievements. At the end of a campaign, campaign quests get resolved and any that are fulfilled unlock new

content or provide permanent benefits for future campaign runs.

Enemy Reference Cards
Every enemy type is represented by a unique reference card that shows different stats and abilities of that enemy type.

AI Cards
AI cards are assigned to enemy groups to determine their behavior, initiative and activation of special abilities for that round.

Enemy Traits
Enemy traits are simple as well as explosive modifiers that can change the strength or abilities of different enemies.

Evil Spells
Some enemies make use of powerful spells, in which case the players draw from this pile and perform its instructions.

Injury Cards
Sometimes, a hero that gets hit will suffer an injury that causes various drawbacks the hero has to deal with.

Game Boards
There are four double-sided game boards with a tactical grid on them. Each adventure will require several of these boards to comprise the entire dungeon or battlefield.

Tokens
There are various tokens to help track volatile resources like health and stamina, but also to assign status effects to enemies (like stun, daze, crippled etc.).

The Golden Rule

Dire Beginnings is a cooperative game. When the rules leave a choice to the party, the players may choose the option most beneficial to them, provided it follows the rules below.

Specific Rules Take Priority
The rulebook provides the default rules. A specific instruction on a card or in the Questbook overrides a default rule where they conflict. Apply that exception only to the situation it describes; all other rules still apply. An instruction that explicitly addresses the current situation takes priority over a more general instruction. Simply omitting a restriction does not remove it.

Simultaneous Effects
Whenever two or more effects would occur at the same time, follow any order specified by the rules. If no order is specified, the party may resolve those effects in whichever order is most beneficial to them. Resolve each effect fully before proceeding to the next, unless an Interrupt or another rule allows otherwise.

Choosing the order does not allow the party to skip mandatory effects, ignore costs, or move an effect to a different point in the turn or round.

Unclear or Missing Rules
If two equally specific instructions conflict, or a situation is not covered, first check the relevant rulebook section, keyword, and Questbook instructions.

If the answer remains unclear, agree on a reasonable temporary ruling and continue playing. Favor an interpretation that fits the existing rules and requires the fewest additional assumptions. If several interpretations remain equally reasonable, the party may choose the one most beneficial to them.

Apply that ruling consistently for the remainder of the adventure, and note the question for later clarification. This fallback does not override a clear rule simply because another outcome would benefit the party.

Core Concepts

This section will explore various core concepts of *Dire Beginnings* to give you a holistic overview about the game's mechanics and most relevant aspects.

Heroes and Enemies

Dire Beginnings is a cooperative game. The players work together against the dangers of the dungeon, which are controlled by the game itself.

There are two main sides:

Heroes are controlled by the players. They use Stamina, equipment, ability cards, and class-specific rules to explore the dungeon, fight enemies, and complete objectives.

Enemies are controlled by the game system. Each round, enemies receive randomized behavior through AI cards, then resolve that behavior using clear and predictable rules.

Unless stated otherwise, the word "enemy" refers to any monster, villain, or hostile entity that opposes the heroes.

Some heroes may also control allied minions or summoned models. These are usually considered part of the heroes' side, but follow their own specific rules.

Adventures and Progression

A game of *Dire Beginnings* is played as an adventure. Each adventure presents a dungeon or scenario, a set of objectives, enemy encounters, special rules, and rewards.

Many adventures are connected through larger questlines. As your party progresses, you may encounter new items, abilities, enemies, and other benefits. However, the game will also become more dangerous as new threats emerge and the campaign escalates.

Your goal is not only to survive each individual adventure, but to grow stronger over time and prepare for the powerful villains waiting at the end of each questline.

Spaces, Range and Movement

The game board is divided into square spaces. Heroes, enemies, minions, and other models move and fight across this grid.

Most models occupy one space. Unless a rule says otherwise, multiple models cannot occupy the same space.

When a model moves, it spends movement points. Each movement point allows that model to move one space.

Diagonal movement is allowed by default. Diagonal attacks and effects are also allowed, as long as the target is within range and any other requirements are met.

To check range, count the number of spaces between the source and the target, including diagonal spaces as one space each. If the counted distance is equal to or lower than the listed range, the target is within range.

Attacks and spells that state a limited range also require a **Line of Sight**. In simple terms, this means the source must be able to "see" the target without a wall or blocking line between them. The exact rules for measuring Line of Sight are explained later in the rulebook.

Dice and Checks

Dire Beginnings uses six-sided dice, eight-sided dice, and ten-sided dice, written as d6, d8, and d10.

Many actions require a check. Attacks, defenses, spellcasting, and certain special effects are all examples of checks.

To make a check, roll the listed dice. The default difficulty is 4+, which means each die showing a 4 or higher counts as one success. Some rules may use a different difficulty.

For attacks, each success usually deals 1 damage. Other checks may use successes in different ways.

Dice Options

Some weapons, items, and abilities provide dice options. A dice option allows you to spend a die showing a specific result to trigger a specific effect.

When you use a die for an option, set that die aside. It no longer counts toward the normal result of the check.

For example, if you are making an attack and use one of your successful dice to activate an option, that die no longer deals its normal 1 damage.

Each option can only be activated once per action, unless a rule specifically says otherwise.

Dice options listed as [1] [4] for example describe a range. Any one die from 1 to 4 can be used to trigger that option.

In case an option lists "x2", it does not mean the option can be used several times. It means that it requires two dice of the listed type to trigger that option.

Reroll Limitations

Some rules allow a player to reroll one or more dice.

Each die can only be rerolled once. After a die has been rerolled, the new result must be kept.

A rerolled die cannot be rerolled again by another ability, item, trait, or effect.

If multiple reroll effects could apply to the same roll, choose which dice to reroll and which effect is used before rerolling.

Stamina

Stamina is one of the most important resources in *Dire Beginnings*. It determines how much a hero can do during a round.

At the beginning of each round, every hero rolls to determine how much Stamina they have available for that round. A hero can spend Stamina to move, attack, use abilities, defend, and perform other actions.

Each hero class has a maximum Stamina value. A hero cannot have more Stamina than their current maximum.

During their turn, a hero may spend any amount of their available Stamina, then end their turn. A hero may also keep some Stamina unspent, allowing them to react later in the round or use specific abilities outside their own turn.

This creates an important choice: spend your Stamina now to act aggressively, or hold some back in case the dungeon turns against you.

Fatigue

Fatigue represents exhaustion, strain, and the cost of pushing beyond your limits.

When a hero suffers Fatigue, their maximum Stamina is reduced. This makes Fatigue especially dangerous over time, because it limits how much that hero can do in future rounds.

Heroes may suffer Fatigue from certain abilities, enemy effects, adventure rules, or by pushing themselves during Stamina generation.

A hero cannot voluntarily suffer Fatigue if their current Fatigue is already equal to their maximum Stamina.

Surplus fatigue (that goes beyond a hero's maximum Stamina) is simply discarded.

When a hero suffers Fatigue, they may lose available Stamina if their new maximum cannot hold it.

Health, Damage and Death

Every hero and enemy has a Health value. Health shows how much damage that model can suffer before it is defeated.

When an enemy is reduced to 0 Health, it is usually removed from the board.

When a hero is reduced to 0 Health, that hero dies. Dead heroes can only return through Resurrection Boons, other special rules or after the remaining party finished an adventure. Resurrection Boons are limited during each adventure, so every death brings the party closer to failure.

Heroes usually deal damage by making attacks, casting spells, and using abilities. Many attacks require a roll against the enemy's Defense value. Each success usually deals 1 damage, though dice options, equipment, and abilities may increase or modify this damage.

Enemies do not usually roll to deal damage. Instead, enemy attacks deal a fixed amount of damage. When a hero is attacked, they may be able to actively defend by spending Stamina. After that, their armor may allow them to make a Toughness check to reduce the damage further.

Armor can save a hero's life, but relying on it is risky. Toughness checks may also cause Injuries, making repeated attacks increasingly dangerous.

Game Setup

This section explains how to start a new campaign and how to set up an individual adventure.

If this is your first time playing Dire Beginnings, follow the steps in order.

Starting A Campaign

A campaign of *Dire Beginnings* is played across a series of adventures. During a campaign, your party gains levels, earns rewards and works toward long-term Campaign Quests.

Before you play the first adventure of a new campaign, follow these steps:

1. Commit to Campaign Quests
2. Set up your party
3. Choose your first adventure
4. Build the map
5. Prepare the heroes

Commit To Campaign Quests

Before starting a new campaign, the players must commit to their Campaign Quests.

Dire Beginnings includes legacy elements. This means that certain achievements can permanently unlock new content and gameplay benefits across all future campaigns. These achievements are called **Campaign Quests**.

Campaign Quests represent special challenges that may ask you to defeat certain enemies, complete adventures under specific conditions, play at higher difficulties, or overcome unusual restrictions.

There are 23 Campaign Quests. They are presented in a recommended order, but you are free to choose any Campaign Quests you want, as long as you meet their requirements.

At the start of the game, you may commit to up to **3 Campaign Quests**, though consider that the "Punch Above Weight" (see campaign difficulty section) rule may grant you additional slots.

During the campaign, track your progress toward your committed Campaign Quests. However, Campaign Quests are only resolved after you complete the 7th adventure of that campaign.

For each committed Campaign Quest you successfully completed, gain its listed reward. Any unlocked content or permanent benefit is available in all future campaigns.

Each Campaign Quest also lists a required difficulty. A Campaign Quest can only be completed if the campaign was played at that difficulty or higher.

Campaign Failure

Since a campaign can fail altogether - when all heroes die simultaneously and no one survives the end of an adventure, campaign quests can also fail this way.

If a campaign fails, all campaign quests fail as well and have to be attempted anew.

Setup Your Party

A party consists of **4 heroes** by default, but you can check the rules on playing with 3 heroes.

Each participating player chooses which hero they want to control. If you are playing with fewer than 4 players, one or more players must control multiple heroes.

You can also play *Dire Beginnings* solo. In a solo game, you control all 4 heroes yourself — or 3, if you play with that optional rule, which is strongly recommended for solo play.

At the start of the game, only the ten starting hero classes are available. Additional hero classes may be unlocked through Campaign Quests or by completing questbooks.

Each hero class begins the campaign with a specific set of starting abilities and equipment. You can find a list of these for each hero class at the end of this rule book.

The party begins with zero gold coins in their coffer, and none of the heroes has available experience points.

After choosing heroes, each player takes the following for each hero they control:

- The hero's reference card
- The hero's starting ability cards
- The hero's starting equipment cards
- The matching hero standee
- Health tokens equal to the hero's maximum Health
- Stamina tokens equal to the hero's maximum Stamina

Hero Reference Cards

The three stats in the top right corner of a hero card are their maximum health, maximum stamina and their speed.

In the top right are their attributes, which determine available slots for future trait cards.

Below the title, the dots determine how many abilities of that type this hero can ever have.

The passive ability at the bottom is always in play, and provides that hero with a strong baseline identity.

Choose an Adventure

The party now chooses an adventure that matches their current party level.

A new campaign begins at party level 1, so the first adventure must be a level 1 adventure.

If this is your first campaign, start with the first adventure of the Crownfall campaign:
A1: The Strange Sorcerer

After each completed adventure, the party level increases by 1, even if it failed. The next adventure you choose must match your new party level.

Once you have chosen an adventure, open the corresponding entry in the Questbook.

Build Map

Each adventure in the Questbook shows a schematic map of the dungeon.

Find the game boards whose wall layouts match the schematic shown in the Questbook. Assemble those boards so their overall formation matches the adventure map.

The large entrance with the stairs usually marks the heroes' starting position. This entrance contains 4 spaces.

Place the 4 chosen hero standees on the entrance spaces. The players may choose the heroes' starting formation freely.

Then place all visible elements shown in the first room or corridor of the Questbook, such as:

- Doors
- Enemies
- Props
- Objective tokens
- Special terrain or adventure-specific markers

Do not place anything from unrevealed rooms unless the Questbook specifically tells you to do so.

> **The Seer Rule**
> Normally, all players can look into the questbook to check what awaits them.
>
> For parties who prefer more of an immersive feeling of exploration, designate one player as the "Seer". Only they may look into the questbook and read aloud narrative texts.
>
> The Seer should not spoil specific room contents, but they can make vague suggestions like: "Let's check out the room to the east first."

Prepare Heroes

Each hero begins the adventure in their starting state:

- Full Health
- No available Stamina
- No Fatigue
- No Injury cards
- All ability cards available

Each player may choose which of their hero's items are equipped at the start of the adventure. Any unequipped items are placed in that hero's backpack.

See the Equipment section for the full rules on equipped items and backpack items.

Once the map is built and all heroes are prepared, read the adventure introduction in the Questbook and begin the first round.

Round Structure

An adventure is played over a series of rounds. Continue playing rounds until the adventure objective is completed, the objective is failed, or all heroes are dead.

Each round is resolved in the following order:

1. Start of Round
2. Stamina Checks
3. Initiative Planning
4. Hero and Enemy Turns
5. End of Round

Start of Round

At the start of each round, resolve the following steps in order:

1. Advance the Doom Clock
2. Assign Enemy AI Cards

3. Resolve Beginning of Round effects

Advance The Doom Clock

Adventures use a Doom Clock to represent mounting danger, limited time, or the dungeon tightening its claws around the heroes.

The Questbook tells you the Doom Clock's starting value. During setup, place a token on that space of the Doom Clock tracker.

At the start of each round, decrease the Doom Clock by 1, but do not decrease the Doom Clock during the first round of an adventure.

If the Doom Clock would decrease below 0, it remains at 0. Then each living hero must Banish 1 of their ability cards. A hero may choose a card from their hand or from their discard pile.

A Banished ability card is unavailable for the rest of the adventure. It returns to that hero only after the adventure is complete.

If a hero must Banish an ability card but has no ability cards left, that hero dies. Remove their hero standee from the board and mark the space where they died.

Assign Enemy AI Cards

Each active enemy group has a corresponding enemy reference card on the initiative track.

During this step, assign 1 AI card to each active enemy reference card.

To do this, draw the top card of the face-down AI deck and place it on the enemy reference card. If the AI deck is empty, shuffle the discarded AI cards to form a new face-down AI deck, then continue drawing.

Enemy groups draw AI cards in order of their distance to the adventure entrance. The enemy group closest to the entrance draws first, followed by the next closest, and so on.

Measure this distance by walking distance. If an enemy group has multiple models, use the model in that group that is closest to the entrance.

If two or more enemy groups are tied, the players choose the order between those tied groups.

Once all enemy AI cards have been assigned, the players may inspect them. This means the party knows when enemies will act, which targets they are likely to choose, and whether any special enemy abilities will trigger this round.

Use this information carefully during Initiative Planning.

Resolve "Beginning of Round" Effects

Some abilities, adventure rules, enemy rules, or ongoing effects may resolve at the beginning of the round.

Resolve those effects now.

If multiple effects must be resolved at the same time, the players choose the order unless a rule specifically says otherwise.

Stamina Checks

Each **living** hero now makes a Stamina Check.

By default, a hero rolls **4d6** with a **difficulty of 4+**.

For each **success**, that hero **gains 1 Stamina**.
A hero gains **another +1 Stamina** by default.
Therefore the amount gained is **1 + Successes**.

Unspent Stamina remains from round to round, but a hero's current Stamina can never exceed their current maximum. Any Stamina gained beyond that maximum is lost.

A hero's maximum Stamina is shown on their hero reference card and is reduced by Fatigue.

After rolling, a player may choose to suffer 1 Fatigue to reroll any number of dice from that Stamina Check.

As an exception to the rule, this may be repeated as many times as the player wants, as long as they are willing to suffer more Fatigue. However, remember that Fatigue reduces the hero's maximum Stamina, so pushing too far may leave the hero with less room to benefit from a better roll.

Initiative Planning

The players now choose the order in which the heroes will act this round.

Place the hero reference cards on the initiative track in the desired order.

Enemy AI cards show an Initiative value from 1 to 4. This value determines after which hero that enemy group acts.

Use the following structure:

First Hero → Enemies with Initiative 1 → Second Hero → Enemies with Initiative 2 → Third Hero → Enemies with Initiative 3 → Fourth Hero → Enemies with Initiative 4

If multiple enemy groups act in the same Initiative slot, they act in the order in which their AI cards were assigned earlier this round.

Once the players commit to the initiative order, the round proceeds to Hero and Enemy Turns.

> **Initiative Example**
> Let's say there are two active enemies, a group of Undead who drew an AI card with an initiative of 2, and a group of Critters with an initiative of 3.
> The heroes determine their desired order as: Bard → Knight → Wizard → Assassin
>
> With that desired order in mind, the Undead will insert themselves after the Knight (since they want to act after the second hero), and the Critters will act after the Wizard.
>
> The initiative tracker should look like this: Bard → Knight → **Undead** → Wizard → **Critters** → Assassin

Hero & Enemy Turns

Heroes and enemies now take their turns in initiative order.

Hero turns and enemy turns are explained in their own sections later in this rulebook.

End Of A Round

At the end of the round, resolve the following steps:

1. Resolve End of Round effects
2. Discard all assigned Enemy AI cards

If multiple End of Round effects must be resolved at the same time, the players choose the order unless a rule specifically says otherwise.

After all End of Round steps are complete, begin a new round unless the adventure has ended.

Hero Turns

This section explains how heroes take their turns and what actions they can perform.

Taking A Turn

Each hero takes one turn per round.

During their turn, a hero may spend any amount of their available Stamina to perform actions, play abilities, move, attack, interact, or use items.

A hero does not have to spend all of their Stamina during their turn. They may spend none of it, spend only part of it, or spend all of it.

When the player controlling the hero declares that they are done, that hero's turn ends and initiative continues.

Any unspent Stamina remains with that hero and may be used later, whether later in the same round or in future rounds. However, a hero's current Stamina can never exceed their current maximum Stamina.

Basic Actions

Every hero can perform the following basic actions by spending Stamina.

A hero may perform the same basic action multiple times during their turn, unless that action says otherwise.

Move

Cost: **1 Stamina**.

The hero gains movement points equal to their current Speed.
Movement points can be spent to:

- Move across the board
- Re-equip items
- Trade items with adjacent heroes
- Use special movement options provided by items or abilities

Each movement point allows the hero to move 1 space.

Unused movement points are lost as soon as the hero performs any other action, including another basic action or an ability. Opening a door does not end movement.

Standard Attack

Cost: **1 Stamina**.

The hero performs one attack with an equipped weapon against an enemy within that weapon's range.

If the hero has more than one weapon equipped, they must choose which weapon they are attacking with before rolling.

A hero may perform only one Standard Attack per weapon per round, and never more than two Standard Attacks total per round.

This means:

- A hero with one two-handed weapon may attack once with that weapon.
- A hero with two one-handed weapons may attack once with each weapon, spending 1 Stamina for each attack.
- A hero may attack with one weapon, later re-equip a different weapon from their backpack, and then attack with that new weapon, as long as they do not exceed two Standard Attacks total that round.

Abilities that include attacks do not count as Standard Attacks and therefore do not count against the above limits.

Meditate

Cost: **2 Stamina**.

The hero attempts to ready discarded abilities.

Roll 1d6 for each of that hero's discarded ability cards. Each die showing 4+ is a success.

The hero may return a number of discarded ability cards to their hand equal to 1 + the number of successes, up to a maximum of 3 cards.

The player chooses which discarded ability cards return to their hand. Any remaining discarded abilities stay in the discard pile.

Even with no successes, Meditate returns 1 discarded ability card to the hero's hand.

Interact

Cost: **1 Stamina**.

The hero interacts with something in their space or an adjacent space.

Common interactions include:

- Opening a treasure chest
- Activating an objective
- Searching or examining something described by the Questbook
- Using an adventure-specific object

When a hero interacts with a treasure chest or objective, refer to the Questbook and resolve the listed effect.

Use Consumable

Cost: **1 Stamina**.

The hero uses one consumable item from their backpack.

Resolve the consumable's effect, then discard it by shuffling it back into the item pile.

Playing Ability Cards

A hero may play any ability card from their hand as long as they can pay its cost and meet its requirements.

Ability cards may cost Stamina, Fatigue or Health, as displayed in the top right corner of the card. The number of pips shown on the card indicates how much of that resource must be paid.
A green dot indicates a card without cost.

After paying the cost, resolve the ability's effects, then place that ability card in the hero's discard pile.

A hero may play ability cards only during their own turn unless the card has a keyword or effect that allows it to be played at another time.

A hero may play any number of ability cards so long as they can afford their costs.

A given ability can only be used once per round, even if it is used and regained in the same round: it cannot be used a second time.

Ongoing Ability Effects

Some abilities create effects that remain in play without a fixed duration. These may include tokens, summoned minions, placed effects, persistent bonuses, or other effects that stay active until something causes them to end or be used up.

After resolving an ability with an ongoing effect, discard the ability card as normal unless the card says otherwise. The ongoing effect remains active even while the card is in the discard pile.

A hero may return that ability card to their hand through Meditate or other effects as normal. Returning the card to hand does not end the ongoing effect.

An ongoing effect ends when one of the following happens:

- The effect's own rules say it ends.
- The hero plays the same ability card again, even through a Repeat option.
- Another rule, ability, or Questbook instruction removes it.

If a hero plays the same ability card again, the previous ongoing effect created by that card immediately ends before the new effect is resolved.

If the previous effect placed tokens on the board, remove those tokens before placing the new ones.

If the previous effect summoned minions, remove those minion standees from the board before placing the newly summoned minions.

Unless a rule says otherwise, a hero can only have one active ongoing effect from the same ability card at a time.

Abilities Tokens

Some abilities, like the totems, traps and other abilities place tokens on spaces.

Every space can only hold a single ability token, regardless of its source. If a space already has an ability token, a different one cannot be stacked on top of it.

Models can move over ability tokens as if these spaces were unoccupied.

Abilities That Change Forms

Some abilities will ask the hero to enter a specific form, like Bear Form, Demon Form etc. A hero can only be in one form at a time.

When applying a new form, the old form immediately ends.

Recovering Fatigue

When a hero ends their turn, they **Rest 1** (recover 1 Fatigue) if they did not perform any Standard Attacks and did not play any ability cards from their hand during that turn.

The hero may still perform other actions and remain eligible to recover Fatigue. This includes moving, interacting, meditating, using consumables, trading items, or re-equipping items.

Recovering Fatigue this way happens only when the hero's turn ends.

This is the default way to recover Fatigue. Other abilities, traits, items, or adventure rules may provide additional ways to recover Fatigue.

Should a hero be **fully fatigued** at the end of their turn and they adhere to the above restrictions, they **Rest 2** instead to help them get back into the action faster.

Assist Action

Heroes can support each other during critical moments, helping turn a poor roll into a better result or creating the exact die result needed to trigger a dice option.

Assist is an action a hero may perform **outside** their own turn.

A hero may Assist **after** another hero has rolled dice for an attack, Spellcasting Check, or Defense Check, but **before** that roll is resolved.

To Assist, the assisting hero must:

1. Spend 1 Stamina.
2. Move 1 space toward the hero they are assisting. Skip this if they are already adjacent.
3. Become adjacent to that hero after this movement.
4. Roll 2d6.
5. Choose 1 of the rolled dice.
6. Replace 1 die from the assisted hero's roll with the chosen die.

The replaced die is removed from the roll and no longer has any effect.

The assisted hero may use the new die as if they had rolled it themselves. It may count as a normal success, deal damage, help succeed at a Spellcasting Check, reduce damage during a Defense Check, or be spent to trigger a dice option.

A hero can only Assist if the 1-space movement would make them adjacent to the hero they are assisting. If they cannot become adjacent, they cannot Assist.

Assisting does not count as taking a turn. A hero may Assist even if they have already taken their turn this round, as long as they can pay the Stamina cost.

Unless a rule says otherwise, each roll can only be affected by a single Assist, no matter if a die was actually replaced or not.

Interrupts

Some abilities have the Interrupt keyword.

Interrupt abilities may be played outside the hero's own turn. They can be played when their listed timing or requirement is met. If no specific timing is listed, they may be played at any time.

When a hero plays an Interrupt ability, immediately pay its cost, resolve its effect, then discard it. After that, resume the previous game flow.

Playing an Interrupt does not count as taking that hero's turn.

If a hero plays an Interrupt that allows them to move, then they move first, then any enemy that was interrupted will reconsider their target prioritization.

If an enemy is killed by an interrupt ability before it could commit to its attack or special ability, then its attack / ability was successfully prevented.

Rush

Some abilities have the Rush keyword.

Rush abilities allow a hero to act earlier than normal.

A hero may play a Rush ability outside their own turn. When they do, immediately pay its cost and resolve the ability similar to an **Interrupt**. After that that hero **takes their full turn** immediately.

Their position on the initiative track remains unchanged, and the Rush turn does not alter the order in which enemies activate.

If the hero takes their turn this way, they skip their normal turn later in the initiative order this round.

If the hero has already taken their turn this round, they may still play a Rush ability. In that case, resolve the Rush ability like an Interrupt, but the hero does not take another full turn.

If hero plays a Rush ability **during** their own turn, it is only played as an Interrupt and has no further impact on initiative.

A hero can never take more than one full turn in the same round unless a rule specifically says otherwise.

Minion Turns

Minions are allied models that fight alongside the hero party.

Some minions are gained through adventure rules, while others are created by hero abilities, passive effects, or summoning.

Unless a rule says otherwise, minions are considered allies and belong to the heroes' side.

Minion Ownership

Every minion must belong to one specific hero.

If a minion is created by a hero ability, it belongs to the hero who created it.

If a minion is gained through an adventure rule, the Questbook may say which hero controls it. If it does not, the players choose which hero the minion belongs to when the minion enters play.

A hero controls all minions that belong to them.

Minion Initiative

A minion shares initiative with the hero it belongs to.

When that hero takes their turn, the controlling player chooses when the minion acts:

- The minion may take its turn immediately before the hero's turn.

- The minion may take its turn immediately after the hero's turn.

A minion can only take one turn per round.

If a hero controls multiple minions, each of those minions may take its turn before or after the hero's turn. The controlling player chooses the order.

Minions do not make Stamina Checks and are not placed separately on the initiative track.

> **Minions of Dead Heroes**
> Since dead heroes do not take turns, the minions of a dead hero simply act at the very end of a round, after all enemies and heroes.

Minion Actions

Minions are simpler than heroes.

During its turn, a minion may (in this order):

1. Move up to its Speed.
2. Perform one attack.

A minion does not spend Stamina to move or attack.

After moving, the minion may attack a valid target using its listed attack dice, range, and rules.

Unless a rule says otherwise, minions do not have dice options.

Minion Restrictions

Minions cannot perform hero actions.

Minions cannot:

- Interact with objectives
- Open treasure chests
- Carry or use items
- Meditate
- Assist
- Block
- Dodge
- Make a toughness check - unless something explicitly grants them Armor.

Adventure rules may override these restrictions for specific minions.

Minion Damage

Minions suffer damage like heroes and enemies.

Track damage on each minion separately. If a minion has damage equal to or greater than its Health, it is defeated and removed from the board.

Minions do not suffer Injuries.

Summoning Minions

Many minions enter play through summoning abilities.

When a hero summons a minion, place that minion on an unoccupied space adjacent to the summoning hero.

If there is no legal unoccupied adjacent space, place the minion on the closest legal unoccupied space instead. If several spaces are equally close, the summoning hero chooses.

A summoned minion belongs to the hero who summoned it.

Re-Summoning Minions

Abilities that summon minions follow the normal rules for ongoing effects.

This means that a summoning ability can be returned to the hero's hand while the summoned minion remains in play.

If the hero plays the same summoning ability again, remove the previous minions created by that ability before placing the new ones.

Because minions may act before or after their hero's turn, a summoning hero may have an existing minion act before their own turn, then play the summoning ability during their turn to

replace that minion, and then have the newly summoned minion act after the hero's turn.

This is explicitly allowed.

Unless a rule says otherwise, a hero can only have one active set of minions from the same summoning ability at a time.

Movement And Positioning

This section explains how models move across the board, how range and Line of Sight are measured, and how terrain affects positioning.

Models and Spaces

The game board is divided into square spaces.

Most models occupy 1 space. Some larger models occupy 2 spaces, as explained under Big Models.

A model can only end its movement on an unoccupied space, unless a rule specifically says otherwise.

If a model cannot legally enter or end on a space, it cannot move there. If no legal movement remains, that model must stop moving early.

Moving Through Models

Models may move through allied models, but not through enemy models.

For heroes, this means:

- Heroes may move through other heroes.
- Heroes may move through allied minions.
- Heroes may not move through enemies.

For enemies, this means:

- Enemies may move through other enemies.
- Enemies may not move through heroes.
- Enemies may not move through allied minions controlled by heroes.

Movement Rules

Models move one space at a time.

Each movement point allows a model to move 1 space, unless the space has difficult terrain or another rule changes the cost.

Diagonal movement is allowed by default.

A model cannot move through white walls, red blocking lines, blue edge lines, or any other boundary that cannot be crossed.

If a model moves diagonally, both spaces beside that diagonal path do not need to be open unless a rule specifically says otherwise. Only the destination space and the line crossed by the movement must be legal.

Range

Many attacks, spells, and abilities list a range.

To check range, count the number of spaces from the source to the target. Diagonal spaces count as 1 space.

If the number of counted spaces is equal to or lower than the listed range, the target is within range.

Unless a rule says otherwise, an attack or ability with a listed range also **requires Line of Sight**.

Line Of Sight

Line of Sight, or LOS, determines whether one model can see another model or space.

To check Line of Sight, draw an imaginary line from the center of the source's space to the center of the target's space.

Line of Sight is blocked if that line crosses:

- A white wall line
- A red blocking line
- Any terrain or prop that specifically blocks Line of Sight

If the line only touches the exact outer corner of a blocking space or line, Line of Sight is still available.

If either the source or target occupies multiple spaces, use any one of the spaces occupied by that model. Line of Sight is available if at least one valid center-to-center line can be drawn.

Adjacency

A model is adjacent to another model or space if it is directly next to it, either orthogonally or diagonally.

Adjacency also requires Line of Sight. If a wall, blocking line, or other obstacle prevents Line of Sight between the two spaces, they are not considered adjacent.

Many attacks, abilities, interactions, and enemy effects require adjacency.

Allies

Some abilities refer to allies.

Unless a rule says otherwise, an ally is:

- The hero using the ability
- Another hero
- A minion or summoned model controlled by the heroes

This means a hero may usually choose themselves as an ally, unless specifically excluded.

Hearing Range

Some effects use Hearing Range instead of normal range or Line of Sight.

Hearing Range is measured by walking distance. Count the number of spaces it would take to move from the source to the target. Ignore difficult terrain, and you may count across blue lines and over low props.

Hearing Range can travel around corners and does not require Line of Sight.

Unless a rule lists a different value, a target is within Hearing Range if it is within **8 spaces** by walking distance.

Terrain and Props

The board and Questbook may include terrain, props, walls, and special markings. These affect movement, Line of Sight, or both.

White Walls

White wall lines represent room walls.

Models cannot move through white walls and Line of Sight cannot be drawn through them.

Red Blocking Lines

Props or spaces marked with red lines are tall or solid enough to block movement and vision.

Models cannot move through red blocking lines or draw Line of Sight through them.

Models cannot occupy spaces covered by red blocking terrain unless a rule specifically says otherwise.

Blue Edge Lines

Blue lines represent edges that can be seen over, but not crossed.

Line of Sight can be drawn over blue lines.

Models cannot move across blue lines.

If a blue-lined prop has open edges, models may enter or leave it through those open edges.

Low Props

Props like chairs or tables without a colored blocking line are considered low props.

Models cannot occupy spaces containing low props but Line of Sight **can** be drawn over them.

Low Props with a Grid
Certain props have the regular grid painted across them, namely the dungeon entrance, carpet, ritual circle and stairs.

In these cases, models can occupy their spaces as per usual.

Difficult Terrain
Some spaces are marked as difficult terrain if it indicates an "x2" in its square.

A model must spend 2 movement points to enter a difficult terrain space instead of 1.

If a model does not have enough movement points to pay this cost, it cannot enter that space.

Enemies always choose the most efficient legal path toward their goal. This means they account for difficult terrain when moving. If walking around difficult terrain would require fewer movement points than crossing it, the enemy will move around it.

Big Models
Some enemies, summoned minions, or special models are Big.

A Big model occupies 2 spaces at once.

When a Big model moves, move both spaces of its base together. Both spaces it occupies after moving must be legal spaces.

A Big model cannot occupy spaces that are separated by a white wall, red blocking line, blue edge line, or any other boundary that cannot be crossed.

Rotating Big Models
A Big model may rotate as part of its movement.

When a Big model rotates, at least 1 space it occupies after the rotation must be a space it occupied before the rotation.

A rotation must still result in a legal position. The Big model cannot rotate through walls, blocking terrain, or occupied spaces unless a rule allows it.

A movement with rotation still just costs 1 movement point.

Big Models and Displacement
Big models treat all non-Big models as **Light**.

This means a Big model may displace non-Big models by moving into their spaces.

When a model is displaced, move it to the nearest legal unoccupied space. The players choose the space if several spaces are equally valid.

A displaced model cannot be moved through walls, blocking terrain, or other illegal boundaries.

If there is no legal space for the displaced model, the Big model cannot move into that space unless a rule specifically says otherwise.

Attacks and Combat
This section explains how heroes make attacks, cast spells, trigger dice options, and deal damage to enemies.

Heroes can harm enemies in several ways. The most common are Standard Attacks, attack abilities, and spell abilities.

Attacks
An attack is any action or ability that tells a hero to make an attack.

A hero can make an attack by performing a Standard Attack or by playing an ability card that includes an attack.

Unless a rule says otherwise, attacks require all of the following:

- A valid target
- A weapon that can perform the attack
- Range to the target
- Line of Sight to the target

Weapon Types

Weapons are either melee weapons or ranged weapons.

A ranged weapon is any weapon with a listed Range value.

A melee weapon is any weapon without a listed Range value.

If an ability says Melee Attack, the hero must use an equipped melee weapon.

If an ability says Ranged Attack, the hero must use an equipped ranged weapon.

If an ability simply says Attack, the hero may use either an equipped melee weapon or an equipped ranged weapon.

Unarmed Attacks

If a hero's hand is unoccupied, they can perform an unarmed attack.

Unarmed attacks always roll 2d8, but can never assign more than one die against the defense of the enemy for the sake of dealing damage. Extra damage from dice options can be added as per usual and exceed that limitation.

A hero is allowed to have both hands free, and is then considered to have two 1h weapons of "unarmed combat".

Attack Range

To attack an enemy, the target must be within range of the chosen weapon.

Melee weapons can usually only attack adjacent enemies unless a weapon or ability says otherwise.

Ranged weapons use their listed Range value.

Making an Attack

To make an attack, resolve the following steps in order:

1. Choose an equipped weapon that can perform the attack.
2. Choose a valid enemy target within range and Line of Sight.
3. Gather the dice listed on the chosen weapon.
4. Add or modify dice from the ability, item, trait, or effect being used.
5. Roll all attack dice.
6. Assign dice to any options you want to trigger.
7. Count all remaining dice that meet or exceed the target's Defense.
8. Deal 1 damage for each success.
9. Resolve any additional effects from the attack, like added damage from options or application of status of effects.

Attack Dice and Defense

Each enemy has a Defense value.

When a hero makes an attack, every die that meets or exceeds the target's Defense is a success.

Each success usually deals 1 damage.

For example, if an enemy has Defense 4, each attack die showing 4 or higher is a success.

Some abilities, weapons, traits, or effects may increase the damage dealt, add extra dice, change the required result, or modify the attack in other ways.

An attack is considered successful if the targeted enemy suffered at least one damage token.

Dice Options During Attacks

Some weapons, abilities, items, and traits provide dice options.

After rolling dice, but before counting final damage, the player may assign rolled dice to available options.

A die assigned to an option does not count toward the attack's normal damage.

Each option can only be used once per action unless a rule specifically says otherwise.

During a Standard Attack, the hero may use:

- Options from the attacking weapon
- Options from equipped items that apply to the attack
- Options from traits or other active effects that apply to the attack

During an attack ability, the hero may use:

- Options from the attacking weapon
- Options printed on the ability card
- Options from equipped items, traits, or other active effects that apply to the attack

Attack Abilities

Some ability cards instruct a hero to make an attack.

If an ability includes an attack, the hero must still choose an equipped weapon that can perform that attack.

The ability may add dice, add effects, change the target, or provide additional dice options.

Unless an ability specifically says otherwise, an attack made through an ability follows the normal attack rules.

An ability that deals damage directly is not an attack unless it uses the word attack.

Spellcasting

Some abilities are spells. A spell ability begins with Spellcasting X.

The number after Spellcasting shows how many successes are required to successfully cast the spell.

By default, a hero rolls **4d6** for a Spellcasting Check with a **difficulty of 4+**.

Each die showing 4 or higher is a success.

If the number of successes equals or exceeds the spell's Spellcasting value, the spell succeeds. Resolve the spell's effect as described on the ability card.

If the hero does not roll enough successes, the spell fails. Unless the card says otherwise, a failed spell has no effect and remains in the hero's hand, but its cost is still paid.

Keep in mind that every ability may only be attempted / played once per round, so a failed spell cannot be repeated in the same round, even if the hero could afford its costs.

Dice Options During Spellcasting

Some spells have dice options.

After rolling the Spellcasting Check, the player may assign rolled dice to spell options.

A die assigned to an option does not count as a success for casting the spell.

This means spell options can make a spell more powerful, but may also make the spell harder to cast successfully.

Each spell option can only be used once per action unless a rule specifically says otherwise.

Dice options of spells only unfold if the spell itself is cast successfully.

Spell Range and Targets

Spell abilities list their own range, target, and effect.

Unless a spell says otherwise, the target must be within range and Line of Sight.

Some spells may target allies, spaces, enemies, or the hero casting the spell. Always follow the targeting text on the ability card.

It is viable to first cast a spell and then choose targets based on dice options available.

Dealing Damage

When a model suffers damage, place that many damage tokens next to it.

Damage remains on the model across rounds.

If the total damage on an enemy is equal to or greater than its Health, that enemy is defeated and removed from the board.

If the total damage on a hero is equal to their Health, that hero dies. Hero death is explained in the Health, Damage, and Death section.

Heroes do not hold more damage tokens than their health - surplus damage is discarded.

Defeating Enemies

When an enemy is defeated, remove its model from the board.

If that enemy was the last model of its enemy group, its enemy reference card, AI card and trait cards are immediately discarded.

Any effects that trigger when an enemy is defeated are resolved immediately.

If multiple effects trigger at the same time, the players choose the order unless a rule specifically says otherwise.

Enemies

This chapter explains how enemies work, how enemy groups are represented, and how to read enemy reference cards.

Enemies are controlled by the game system. They use reference cards, AI cards, traits, and clear targeting rules to determine how they behave.

Enemy Groups

Enemies are organized into enemy groups.

An enemy group is represented by one enemy reference card. All models belonging to that reference card are part of the same group.

Enemy groups act together, share the same AI card, and use the same stats, abilities, and traits.

If new enemies of a type that is already active are spawned, they usually join the existing enemy group of that type instead of creating a new group. Add the new models to that group and use the existing reference card.

If the Questbook specifically tells you to create a separate group, use a separate enemy reference card for that group.

Enemy Reference Cards

Each enemy group has an enemy reference card. This card shows the enemy's stats, abilities, passives, and other relevant rules.

An enemy reference card usually represents multiple models, but its Health value applies to each model individually.

Enemy Stats

Enemy reference cards use the following stats.

Health

Health shows how much damage each individual model in the group can suffer before it is defeated.

Damage is tracked separately for each model.

When a model has damage equal to or greater than its Health, it is defeated and removed from the board.

Defense
Defense is the number heroes must meet or exceed when attacking this enemy.

For each attack die that meets or exceeds the enemy's Defense, the attack deals 1 damage unless a rule says otherwise.

Speed
Speed shows how many movement points each model in the group generates during its turn.

Each model moves individually, using the group's Speed value.

Attacks
Attacks shows how many attacks the enemy group can perform collectively during its turn.

This is not the number of attacks each model makes. Instead, it is the total number of models in that group that may attack during the group's turn.

For example, if an enemy group has "Attacks: 2", only up to 2 models in that group may attack during its turn. Any remaining models may still move, but they do not attack.

Unless a rule says otherwise, enemies that are able to attack do so before enemies that cannot attack.

Damage
Damage shows how much damage one attack from this enemy deals.

Enemy attacks deal fixed damage. They do not roll attack dice.

When a hero is attacked by an enemy, the hero may be able to defend and make Toughness Checks to reduce the damage.

Range
Range shows how far the enemy can attack.

Most enemies have no Range value and can only make melee attacks against adjacent targets.

If an enemy has a Range value, it can attack targets within that range and Line of Sight.

Enemy Types and Passives
Enemy reference cards may list passive keywords or enemy types.

Passive keywords are always active.

Enemy types describe what kind of creature or threat the enemy is, such as Animal, Demon, Undead, or Human. Some abilities, traits, or adventure rules may interact with enemy types.

Enemy Abilities
Each enemy reference card has a Minor Ability and a Major Ability.

These abilities are not always active. They are triggered by symbols on the enemy's assigned AI card.

If the AI card shows the Minor Ability symbol, resolve the enemy group's Minor Ability during its turn.

If the AI card shows the Major Ability symbol, resolve the enemy group's Major Ability during its turn.

Some abilities are not triggered at a specific moment, in this case that ability is passively applied across the whole round.

Spawning Enemies
The Questbook tells you when and where enemies spawn.

When enemies spawn, place the listed number of models of the indicated enemy type onto the spaces shown in the Questbook.

If there are not enough models in the supply, place as many as possible and ignore the rest.

If several spawn spaces are shown and not enough models are available for all of them, place models on the spaces closest to the adventure entrance first, measured by walking distance. If there is a tie, the players choose the order.

If a spawned enemy type already has an active enemy group, add the new models to that group unless the Questbook says otherwise. If that group has already acted this round, the new models do not get to act that round.

If no active group of that enemy type exists, place a new enemy reference card for that group on the initiative track, and draw an AI card to determine their initiative. If they receive an initiative step that has already occurred, they act at the very end of that round instead.

Enemy Traits

Enemy groups may gain traits through higher difficulty levels, Questbook instructions, or other special rules.

Traits modify an enemy group and can make enemies more dangerous, stranger, or harder to handle.

There is no fixed limit to how many traits an enemy group can have.

When an enemy group gains a trait, place the trait card near that enemy's reference card.

If multiple enemy groups share the same trait and there is only one copy of that trait card available, place the trait card nearby and mark each affected enemy reference card with a matching token. That token shows which groups are affected by the trait.

Trait effects are active for as long as the affected enemy group remains in play.

When an enemy group is fully defeated and its reference card is removed from the initiative track, discard any traits that only applied to that group.

If a shared trait still applies to at least one other active enemy group, do not discard it. Only remove the token from the defeated group's reference card.

Bosses

Stronger unique enemies may be designated as "bosses" in the questbook. These typically use a specific enemy type as a base, but have more health or a few unique abilities.

Follow the instructions of the questbook to spawn a boss accordingly.

Regular bosses follow the same rules as normal enemies, except for the differences mentioned in the questbook.

Bespoke Bosses

Sometimes, the questbook will designate an enemy as a bespoke boss. A bespoke boss is a uniquely distinct enemy with its own reference card and special rules that apply to them.

Bespoke bosses never receive random traits based on the campaign's difficulty!

Follow the below steps and details to handle the fight against these epic bespoke bosses.

Boss Setup

The Questbook lists the boss's Health and the Boss Ability cards used during each phase.

Gather the cards listed for Phase 1, shuffle them, and place them face down near the boss's reference card. Keep cards for later phases aside.

Boss Abilities

At the end of the boss's turn, but before resolving any **Retreat**, draw and execute the top card of its Boss Ability deck. Then place that card face up in a discard pile.

If the boss must draw a card while its draw deck is empty, shuffle its discarded Boss Ability cards to create a new face-down draw deck.

Wounding A Boss

When a Bespoke Boss has Damage equal to or greater than its current Health, it becomes Wounded instead of being defeated.

Finish resolving the attack or effect that Wounded it, then remove all Damage from the boss. Any excess Damage is lost.

The heroes must then choose one of the following:

- Choose any card currently in the boss's discard pile.
- Take the top card of its draw deck without looking at it.

Reveal the chosen card. The boss immediately executes it as an Interrupt, then Banishes it.

Changing Phase

After a Boss Ability card is Banished, count all cards remaining in the boss's current draw and discard piles.

If only one card remains, remove that card from play without executing it. The boss immediately enters its next phase. Gather and shuffle the Boss Ability cards listed for that phase to create its new draw deck.

If the boss has no next phase, it is defeated instead.

A boss may have additional rules that resolve when it becomes Wounded, enters a new phase, or is defeated. These are listed in the Questbook.

Enemy Turns and AI

This chapter explains how enemies take turns, choose targets, move, attack, and use their abilities.

Enemies are controlled by the game system. Their behavior is determined by their reference card, their assigned AI card, and the rules in this chapter.

Enemy Activation Order

The Round Structure chapter explains how enemy groups are assigned AI cards and when they act during initiative.

When an enemy group takes its turn, each model in that group activates once.

Activate the models in that group one at a time, starting with the model closest to the adventure entrance by walking distance. Then continue in order until the model furthest from the entrance has activated.

If two or more models are equally close to the entrance, the players choose the order between those tied models.

During its activation, an enemy usually does the following:

1. Choose a target.
2. Move toward that target.
3. Attack if able.
4. Resolve any active abilities or special rules.

After one model has finished its activation, activate the next model in the same group.

Once every model in the group has activated, that enemy group's turn ends.

Enemy Targeting

Each assigned AI card lists a targeting priority.

When an enemy activates, use the targeting priority on its AI card to determine which hero or allied minion it tries to attack.

First, use the top targeting line to determine the enemy's primary target. If multiple targets are equally valid, use the second targeting line to break the tie. If there is still a tie after that, the players choose the target.

An enemy only considers targets it could legally attack this activation by using its movement and attack range.

A hero or minion that cannot be legally reached for an attack is ignored when determining the target.

If no hero or allied minion can be reached for an attack, the enemy instead moves toward the closest hero or allied minion by walking distance.

Targeting Priorities

AI cards may use the following targeting priorities.

Least Damaged - The enemy prioritizes the target that has suffered the least damage. Compare the amount of damage currently on each valid target. The target with the lowest amount of damage is prioritized.

Most Damaged - The enemy prioritizes the target that has suffered the most damage. Compare the amount of damage currently on each valid target. The target with the highest amount of damage is prioritized.

Closest - The enemy prioritizes the valid target that requires the fewest movement points to reach and attack. If the enemy has a ranged attack or Reach, count only the movement needed to get the target within attack range.

Furthest - The enemy prioritizes the valid target that is furthest away by walking distance.

Most Fatigued - The enemy prioritizes the target with the most Fatigue tokens.

Enemy Movement

After choosing a target, an enemy moves toward that target.

Enemies always use legal movement and follow the normal movement rules. They cannot move through heroes or allied minions, cannot cross walls or blocking lines, and cannot end their movement on an occupied space.

An enemy only moves as far as necessary to attack its target.

If an enemy has a melee attack, it moves until it becomes adjacent to its target.

If an enemy has Reach or a ranged attack, it moves only until its target is within the required range and Line of Sight.

Enemies choose the most efficient legal path. If difficult terrain would make a route slower, the enemy will move around it when that is more efficient.

If an enemy cannot reach a position from which it can attack any valid target, it moves toward the closest hero or allied minion by walking distance.

Enemy Attacks

Enemies do not roll attack dice.

When an enemy attacks, it deals fixed damage equal to the Damage value on its reference card.

The attacked hero may then defend, dodge, use abilities, and make a Toughness Check to reduce or prevent that damage.

Any remaining damage is added as damage tokens to that hero, reducing their remaining Health.

A hero can never have more damage tokens than they have Health.

Group Attack Limit

An enemy group's Attacks value determines how many models in that group may attack during that group's turn.

For example, if an enemy group has Attacks 2, only the first 2 models in that group that are able to attack may do so. Other models in the group still activate and move normally, but they do not attack.

Track the number of attacks made by the group during its turn. Once the group has made attacks equal to its Attacks value, no further models in that group may attack this turn unless a rule says otherwise.

Models that are able to attack use the group's available attacks before models that are unable to attack.

AI Card Modifiers

Some AI cards include a modifier on their third text line.

If the modifier grants a keyword, changes a stat, or applies a special rule, that modifier affects the enemy group for the **entire round**.

If an enemy group receives **Rush** during the Start of Round, it takes its turn after Stamina Checks and Initiative Planning, before the first scheduled hero turn.

If a newly created enemy group receives Rush during a round, finish resolving the room reveal or other effect that spawned it. The group then immediately takes its turn before the interrupted turn or game sequence resumes.

If multiple enemy groups are waiting to take Rush turns, resolve them in the order their AI cards were assigned.

Heroes may play their own Rush abilities before an enemy Rush turn begins, resolving those abilities and any resulting hero turns normally.

An enemy group that takes a Rush turn does not also act at its normal initiative position that round.

Enemy Abilities

Each enemy reference card has three ability sections:

- Passive abilities
- Minor ability
- Major ability

Passive abilities are usually keywords and are always active unless a rule says otherwise.

Minor abilities are marked with the **blue** minor ability icon.

Major abilities are marked with the **red** major ability icon.

If an AI card or trait shows the corresponding icon, that ability is active for the round.

Unless the ability says otherwise, an active ability applies to every model in that enemy group. If the ability includes an action or effect that each enemy performs, each model performs it during its activation.

At the end of the round, active Minor and Major abilities become inactive unless another AI card, trait, or rule keeps them active.

Evil Spells

Some enemies, traits, or AI cards cause an enemy to resolve an Evil Spell.

At the beginning of each adventure, shuffle the Evil Spell deck and place it face down near the play area.

When an enemy resolves an Evil Spell, draw the top card of the Evil Spell deck and resolve its effect.

If the Evil Spell deck is empty, shuffle the discarded Evil Spell cards to create a new face-down deck.

Unless the Evil Spell says otherwise, discard it after resolving its effect.

Hero Defense and Damage

When a hero is attacked, they may be able to reduce the incoming damage before losing Health.

Resolve damage against a hero in the following order:

1. The enemy determines its damage.
2. The hero may Block or Dodge.
3. Resolve any other damage-reducing abilities or effects.
4. The hero makes a Toughness Check.
5. Apply any remaining damage to the hero's Health.
6. If the hero's Health is reduced to 0, the hero dies.

A hero can either Block or Dodge against a single attack, but not both.

Damage vs. Health Loss

Some effects cause Damage, while others cause a hero to lose Health or pay Health.

These are different.

Damage represents harm from attacks, spells, traps, hazards, and other dangerous effects. Damage can usually be reduced or prevented by Block, Dodge, Toughness Checks, armor, abilities, traits, or items.

Health Loss directly causes a damage token that cannot be reduced by Block, Dodge, Toughness Checks or abilities unless a rule specifically says otherwise.

An ability hat requires paying Health is a cost, not Damage. If an ability requires a hero to pay Health, the resulting damage token cannot be reduced or prevented unless a rule specifically says otherwise.

If a rule says a model "suffers Damage," treat it as Damage.

If a rule says a model "loses Health" or "pays Health," do not treat apply usual means of damage mitigation.

Block

Cost: **1 Stamina**

A hero may Block against a direct attack.

Blocking cannot be used against indirect damage, environmental damage, or damage from effects such as Blast unless a rule specifically allows it.

To Block, spend 1 Stamina and roll 4d6 with a difficulty of 4+.

For each success, reduce the incoming damage by 1.

The hero may add bonus dice from equipped shields, abilities, traits, or other effects that improve Block rolls.

A hero can Block no more than twice per round.

Dodge

Cost: **1 Fatigue**
A hero may Dodge against a direct attack.

Dodging cannot be used against indirect damage, environmental damage, or damage from effects such as Blast unless a rule specifically allows it.

To Dodge, suffer 1 Fatigue and roll 4d6 with a difficulty of 4+.

For each success, reduce the incoming damage by 1.

After resolving the Dodge roll, the hero must move 1 space to a legal unoccupied space.

If the hero cannot move 1 space, they cannot Dodge in the first place.

There is no limit to how many times a hero can Dodge during a round, as long as they can suffer the Fatigue and move legally each time.

Toughness Check

After Blocking, Dodging, and any other damage reduction effects have been resolved, the hero makes a Toughness Check against any remaining damage.

Roll one d6 for each remaining point of damage.

The difficulty of the Toughness Check is determined by the hero's equipped armor.

If the hero is not wearing armor, the difficulty is 6+.

For each success, prevent 1 damage.

It is possible to prevent all remaining damage with a Toughness Check.

After all rerolls and modifications are resolved, if the Toughness Check includes at least one **natural 1**, the hero must draw 1 random Injury card.

After the Toughness Check, apply any remaining damage to the hero's Health.

If the hero's Health is reduced to 0, the hero dies.

During a Toughness Check, a hero can use dice options listed on their worn armor.

Hero Death and Resurrection

Heroes may die during an adventure, but death is not always the end.

Hero Death

A hero dies if any of the following happen:

- Their Health is reduced to 0.
- An objective, event, or rule says they die.
- They must Banish an ability card but have no ability cards left to Banish.

When a hero dies, remove their standee from the board and replace it with a **Fallen Hero token** on the space where they died.

A dead hero does not take turns, does not make Stamina Checks, and is not placed on the initiative track.

If the party survives the adventure, any dead heroes return to life during the next Town Phase unless a rule says otherwise.

Resurrection Boons

Each adventure grants a specific number of Resurrection Boons, usually between 1 and 4.

During setup, place the listed number of Resurrection Boon tokens near the Doom Clock.

Resurrection Boons do not carry over between adventures. Each adventure starts with the number of Resurrection Boons listed in the Questbook.

At the beginning of a round, if at least one hero is dead, the party may spend 1 Resurrection Boon to revive one dead hero.

To revive a hero, remove 1 Resurrection Boon token, remove that hero's Fallen Hero token, and place the hero's standee on that space. If that space is occupied, place the hero on the nearest legal unoccupied space. If several spaces are equally valid, the players choose.

The revived hero immediately gains **Heal 6** and **Rest 2,** and then participates in that round normally. They keep any status tokens or injuries.

If multiple heroes are dead, the party may spend multiple Resurrection Boons at the beginning of the same round, reviving one hero per spent token.

Party Wipe

If at any point all heroes are dead simultaneously - even if minions are still alive - the party was wiped out.

This means an immediate loss of the campaign and forces the party to start a new campaign.

Any Campaign Quests that were committed fail.

Exploration

This section explains how to use the Quest Book, reveal new rooms, open doors, and interact with treasure chests and other adventure features.

Each adventure is divided into rooms. Heroes begin in the starting area shown in the Quest Book, then explore the adventure by opening doors, revealing new rooms, and resolving the instructions tied to those rooms.

The Quest Book

Each adventure in the Quest Book follows the same general structure:

- **Map:** Shows a schematic overview of the adventure and all rooms.
- **Intro Text:** Read this aloud before the adventure begins.
- **Objective:** The main goal heroes must complete to win the adventure and receive at least a one-star result.
- **Rewards:** Lists the requirements for the different star-results, and which rewards are tied to them.
- **Adventure Overview:** Story text or instructions tied to specific rooms, as well as overview on specific triggers and contents of treasure chests.
- **Starting Conditions:** Mentions if any special starting conditions apply.
- **Special Rules:** Additional rules that only apply to this adventure.
- **Outro Text:** Read this aloud once the adventure ends.

Some adventures may have unique starting conditions, but unless the Quest Book says otherwise, heroes begin on or adjacent on the marked dungeon entrance.

Special rules in the Quest Book override the normal rules. If a quest instruction contradicts this rulebook, follow the quest instruction.

Rooms

A room is an area separated from other areas by doors, white walls, red lines, blue lines, or other boundaries shown in the Quest Book.

A room can be a small corridor, a chamber, a courtyard, a cave section, or even a larger outdoor area with several corners and paths. If an area is revealed as one layout in the Quest Book, it counts as one room, even if it has several smaller spaces inside it.

The contents of a room are collectively called its layout. A room's layout can include props, doors, enemies, objective tokens, treasure chests and other markers.

Dungeon Entrance

Most adventures have a marked dungeon entrance. This marks where the heroes begin the adventure.

Some rules refer to the enemy or object closest to the entrance. When this happens, count the shortest valid path from the entrance to determine distance. If two or more options are equally close, the party chooses between them.

Explored and Unexplored Space

Some abilities and quest rules refer to explored or unexplored spaces.

A space is explored if it belongs to a room that has already been revealed.

A space is unexplored if it belongs to a room that has not yet been revealed.

Heroes cannot move into, target, search, or affect unexplored spaces unless a rule specifically allows it. Unexplored rooms do not exist for gameplay purposes until they are revealed.

Opening Doors

When a hero is adjacent to a door token during their turn, they may open that door at no Stamina or movement point cost. This does not end their movement.

Replace the door token with an open door token. Once a door has been opened, it cannot be closed again.

Opening a door immediately reveals the room beyond it. Pause the current turn, reveal the room as described below, then continue the hero's turn if they still have actions or Stamina remaining.

Unless an ability or quest rule says otherwise, only heroes can open doors.

Revealing Rooms

When a room is revealed, place all contents shown in that room's layout in the Quest Book. This includes props, new doors, objective tokens, treasure chests and enemies.

Reveal the entire room at once, even if the hero who opened the door does not have line of sight to every part of the room.

If enemies are revealed, each newly revealed enemy group receives an AI card as normal.

If the initiative insert they would be assigned has already occurred, they act last instead.

Some rooms are marked with a letter or label. When a labeled room is revealed, check the matching entry in the Quest Book. If the entry says to read text aloud or resolve instructions when the room is revealed, do so immediately.

If the entry says to resolve something when a hero enters the room, wait until the first hero moves into that room.

Some entries may have a quest text to read aloud after certain conditions are met - typically when all enemies within are defeated.

Randomized Layout

Some rooms in the Quest Book are marked with a question mark on a golden background. These rooms have randomized layouts.

When revealing a randomized room, roll **1d6** before placing any contents:

- On a 1–2, use the first layout.
- On a 3–4, use the second layout.
- On a 5–6, use the third layout.

After the layout is determined, place all contents shown in that version of the room.

Heroes cannot use rerolls, abilities, items, or other effects to modify this roll unless a rule specifically says it can affect randomized layout rolls.

Treasure Chests

Most adventures contain a few treasure chests.

To open a treasure chest, a hero must be adjacent to it, have line of sight to it, and spend 1 Stamina during their turn.

When a treasure chest is opened, refer to the matching treasure chest entry in the Quest Book and resolve its contents immediately.

If opening the chest requires a dice roll, the hero opening the chest makes that roll. They may use any rerolls or effects available to them, unless the treasure chest entry says otherwise.

After a treasure chest has been opened, it cannot be opened again. Remove the chest token.

Item Rewards with Affixes

Some Questbook rewards list a specific item with one or more affixes shown in brackets.

When this happens, the party gains the listed item with those affixes attached to it.

An item with at least one affix attached to it is considered to be a relic.

Affixes are permanent parts of that item. They cannot be removed, transferred, or replaced unless a rule specifically says otherwise.

If one of the listed affixes is already attached to another item in play, the party may choose a different affix of the same rarity and attach it to the rewarded item instead.

If multiple replacement affixes are needed, choose each replacement separately.

> ### Affix Rarity Types
> There are three rarities among affixes:
> - **Rare** ones have a **blue** title
> - **Epic** ones have a **purple** title
> - **Mythic** ones have an **orange** title

Affix Limits

Every item can hold a maximum of **three affixes**, regardless of its level or overall strength.

If applying new affixes would exceed this limit, you may replace any existing affixes, discarding those you replace. Any remaining surplus affixes must be discarded.

Affix rarity does not affect this limit.

Reaching Item Supply Limit

If a treasure chest rewards an item that the party already possesses and no copies of that item remain in the item deck, do the following:

- Gain gold equal to the item's coin value.
- Any affixes awarded with the item may instead be applied to the copy already in the party's possession.
    - If an awarded affix is already in play, choose another affix of the same rarity instead, as normal.
    - If the item would exceed its affix limit, choose which affixes to apply. Any remaining affixes are lost. You may replace existing affixes with awarded ones.

End-Of-Adventure Auto Collection

Whenever an adventure ends immediately because its objective has been fulfilled, the party automatically collects each treasure chest that is in the same room as at least one hero.

Any treasure chest that is not in the same room as a hero is lost.

Room and Quest Instructions

Some rooms include special instructions, story text, enemies, traps, events, or objectives. Always resolve these instructions at the timing described in the Quest Book.

Common timings include:

- When this room is revealed: Resolve immediately after placing the room.
- When a hero enters this room: Resolve when the first hero moves into the room.
- When a hero interacts with this token: Resolve only after a hero spends the required action or Stamina.
- At the end of the round: Resolve during the End of Round step.
- When the objective is completed: Resolve as soon as the stated objective condition is met.

If multiple quest instructions happen at the same time, the party chooses the order unless the Quest Book says otherwise.

Objective Tokens and Special Instructions

Many adventures use objective tokens to represent prisoners, ritual sites, levers, relics, corpses, barricades, magical seals, or other important features.

Unless the Quest Book says otherwise, a hero must be adjacent to an objective token and spend 1 Stamina to interact with it.

The Quest Book explains what happens when an objective token is interacted with. Some objective tokens can only be used once, while others may be used multiple times.

Items and Equipment

This section explains how heroes carry, equip, use, and modify items.

Items include weapons, armor, shields, accessories, consumables, and special rewards found during adventures.

Equipment Slots

Every hero has the following equipment slots:

- Two hand slots.
- One armor slot.
- One accessory slot.
- A backpack

A hero may equip either:

- Two one-handed items, one in each hand, or
- One two-handed item, using both hand slots

Despite shields being one-handed items, a hero can only equip a single shield at any one time.

A hero may equip one armor item and one accessory item.

A hero's backpack has no item limit. Any number of items can be stored there.

To keep the play area clear, place each hero's equipped items in one row near their hero reference card. Place that hero's backpack items in a separate row below them.

Gaining Items

When a hero gains an item, place it in that hero's backpack by default.

The hero does not automatically equip the item unless a rule specifically says otherwise.

If the party gains an item without assigning it to a specific hero, the players decide which hero receives it.

Equipping Items

A hero may change their equipped items by spending movement points during a Move action.

Each of the following costs **1 movement point**:

- Equip or unequip items in the hero's hand slots, either exchanging one hand item or both at once.
    - *For example, a hero may unequip a shield and a sword to then equip a crossbow, all with a single MP.*
- Change the hero's equipped armor.
- Change the hero's equipped accessory.

Items can only be equipped from that hero's backpack.

Items that are unequipped are placed in that hero's backpack.

A hero must always obey their equipment slot limits. For example, a hero cannot equip a two-handed weapon while also keeping another item equipped in one hand.

Trading Items

A hero may trade items with an adjacent hero by spending movement points during a Move action.

Each trade costs 1 movement point.

Traded items are placed into the receiving hero's backpack unless they immediately spend movement points to equip them. A hero can trade to give an item, or trade to take an item.

Dice Options on Items

Many items provide dice options.

A dice option can only be used during a roll that the item supports.

Weapon dice options can only be used when attacking with that specific weapon.

Shield dice options can only be used during a Block.

Armor dice options can only be used during a Toughness Check unless the item says otherwise.

Accessory dice options can only be used during the type of roll described by the accessory.

If an **affix** adds dice options to an item, those options follow the same timing and roll type as the item they are attached to.

For example, an affix attached to a weapon can only be used when attacking with that weapon. An affix attached to armor can only be used during a Toughness Check unless the affix says otherwise.

Consumables

Consumables are single-use items.

They are always stored in a hero's backpack and do not use equipment slots.

A hero may use a consumable by spending 1 Stamina.

When a hero uses a consumable, resolve its effect, then shuffle it back into the item deck.

A consumable affects the hero using it.

The Town Phase

The Town Phase takes place between adventures. During the Town Phase, heroes recover, spend XP, buy and sell items, adjust their builds, and prepare for the next adventure.

Heroes enter a Town Phase after finishing an adventure, unless that adventure was the final adventure of a campaign. After the final

adventure, the campaign ends and the heroes retire.

During the Town Phase, players may resolve the available steps in **any order**. You may go back and forth between learning abilities, buying items, selling equipment, and adjusting heroes until the party is ready to continue.

The party shares one common supply of gold coins, called the party coffer. All players must collectively agree how to spend gold from the party coffer.

Town Phase Overview

During the Town Phase, the party may do the following:

- Learn abilities
- Unlearn abilities
- Learn traits
- Unlearn traits
- Buy items
- Sell items
- Exchange items between heroes
- Prepare for the next adventure
- Choose the next adventure

Abilities

Abilities are the core tools that define how each hero fights, supports the party, and solves problems during an adventure.

Each hero class has limits for different ability categories. These limits are shown on the hero reference card as dots.

A hero can never have more ability cards of a category than their hero reference card allows.

> **Exclusive Abilities**
> Some abilities are marked as Exclusive to a specific hero class.
>
> Exclusive abilities are never added to the Ability Deck. If one is accidentally drawn while assembling the Ability Display, set it aside and draw another card instead.
>
> Keep all Exclusive abilities that are not currently in play separate from the Ability Deck.

Learning Abilities

During each Town Phase, shuffle the ability deck and **draw 8 ability cards**. Place them face up to create the Ability Display.

Heroes may learn abilities from the Ability Display.

To learn an ability, a hero must:

- Have an available slot for that ability's category
- Be able to pay the ability's XP cost

When a hero learns an ability, spend the listed XP and add the ability card to that hero's ability deck.

There is no limit to how many abilities a hero can learn during a Town Phase, as long as they can afford them and obey their category limits.

Searching for Ability Categories

Once per Town Phase, the party may name four ability categories - the same can be named repeatedly.

Then reveal cards from the ability deck until one card of each named category has been revealed. Add those revealed cards to the Ability Display.

Any other cards revealed during this search are discarded.

Unlearning Abilities

During the Town Phase, a hero may unlearn an ability.

To unlearn an ability, spend 10 gold coins from the party coffer and remove one ability card from that hero's ability deck.

The hero immediately regains XP equal to that ability's XP cost.

Return the removed ability card to the bottom of the ability deck, unless it was an exclusive ability: then put it into the game's box.

Traits

Traits are passive upgrades that make heroes stronger, more specialized, or more flexible during an adventure.

Each hero reference card shows three trait slots in the top right corner. Each slot has an attribute type.

A hero can only equip traits that match their available trait slots.

A flex slot can hold a trait of any attribute type.

Trait Attributes

Traits use the following attributes:

- **Agility,** shown by a teal feather.
- **Intelligence,** shown by a blue crystal.
- **Strength,** shown by a yellow muscled arm.
- **Endurance,** shown by a blue shield.
- **Charisma,** shown by a yellow star.
- **Wisdom,** shown by a purple eye.
- **Flex**, shown by a beige swirl.

Learning Traits

During each Town Phase, shuffle the trait deck and draw **5 trait cards**. Place them face up to create the Trait Display.

Heroes may learn traits from the Trait Display.

To learn a trait, a hero must:

- Have an available trait slot matching that trait's attribute
- Be able to pay the trait's XP cost

When a hero learns a trait, spend the listed XP and place the trait card next to that hero's reference card.

There is no limit to how many traits a hero can learn during a Town Phase, as long as they can afford them and have available matching trait slots.

Unlearning Traits

During the Town Phase, a hero may unlearn a trait.

To unlearn a trait, spend 10 gold coins from the party coffer and remove one trait card from that hero.

The hero immediately regains XP equal to that trait's XP cost.

Return the removed trait card to the bottom of the trait deck.

Items

Items make heroes stronger, more durable, and more adaptable. They include weapons, armor, shields, accessories, consumables, and special rewards.

Any hero can use any item, as long as they have the required equipment slots available.

During the Town Phase, heroes may freely exchange items with each other.

Buying Items

During each Town Phase, shuffle the item deck and **draw 10 item cards**. Place them face up to create the Item Display.

Any item that is three or more levels above the current Hero Level must be discarded, and in its place a new card is drawn. Repeat this until the item's level matches.

The party may buy any items from the Item Display by spending gold coins from the party coffer.

A bought item is given to a hero chosen by the players and placed in that hero's backpack unless they equip it during preparation.

Buying Consumables

Consumables have no base cost.

If a consumable in the Item Display is equal to or lower than the party's current level, the party may take it for free.

If a consumable is above the party's current level, the party must spend 5 gold coins to obtain it.

Searching for Items By Level

Once per Town Phase, the party may choose any item level, up to a maximum of two levels above the Hero Level.

Then reveal cards from the item deck until **3 items** of the chosen level have been revealed.

Add those revealed items to the Item Display.

Any other cards revealed during this search are discarded.

Selling Items

During the Town Phase, heroes may sell items they own.

When an item is sold, add gold coins to the party coffer equal to that item's listed value.

Consumables cannot be sold.

After selling an item, return it to the bottom of the item deck.

> **Full Value**
> Items always sell for their full listed value.
>
> This makes item purchases safe. Buying an item during one Town Phase does not become a permanent mistake, because the party can later sell it to help fund stronger or more useful equipment.

> Players are encouraged to buy items that seem useful now, then trade them in when better options become available.

Selling Items with Affixes

An item with affixes does not increase in sell value.

When selling an affixed item, gain gold equal to the base item's listed value.

Then return the base item to the bottom of the item deck and shuffle the attached affixes back into the affix deck.

> **No Added Value?!**
> The land is collapsing into ruin, and only powerful heroes can awaken the true potential of enchanted items.
>
> To most commoners, militia fighters, and desperate soldiers, a blade is still just a blade. They may gladly buy a sword to protect their homes, but they will not pay extra because some half-forgotten enchantment hums inside it.
>
> In the apocalypse, practical steel has value. Hidden magic is a luxury few can recognize.

Prepare for Next Adventure

Before choosing the next adventure, reset all heroes to their clean starting state.

Shuffle all remaining cards from the displays back into their respective piles.

Then each hero:

- Heals to full Health
- Has no Stamina
- Removes all Fatigue
- Removes all Injury cards and shuffles the injury deck

- Ends all previous ongoing effects (if any)
- Returns all ability cards to their hand
- May freely equip items from their backpack

The party may also freely exchange items between heroes during this step.

Choose the Next Adventure

After all learning, shopping, selling, and preparation is complete, the party chooses the next adventure.

The chosen adventure must:

- Be already unlocked through legacy progression
- Match the party's current Hero Level

After choosing the next adventure, open the corresponding Questbook entry and begin adventure setup.

Campaign and Legacy Rules

Dire Beginnings can be played as a single adventure, but the game is designed to unfold across full campaigns.

A campaign links several adventures together, allowing heroes to grow stronger, earn rewards, unlock new content, and work toward long-term Campaign Quests.

Playing a Campaign

A campaign is a connected series of **7 adventures**.

Each campaign begins at party level 1.
After each completed adventure, the party's Hero Level increases by 1. The number of the next adventure chosen must match the party's current level.

For example, after completing a level 1 adventure, the party becomes level 2 and must choose a level 2 adventure next, e.g. 2A, 2B and so forth.

Each campaign ends after the party completes the 7th adventure. This final adventure usually features a powerful boss, major story resolution, and possible legacy rewards.

After the 7th adventure is complete, the campaign ends. The heroes retire, Campaign Quests are resolved, and the players may begin a new campaign with a new party.

Campaign Difficulty

When starting a campaign, the party must choose a campaign difficulty.

Campaign difficulty affects the entire campaign and cannot be changed until the campaign ends.

Some Campaign Quests require a minimum difficulty. A Campaign Quest can only be completed if the campaign was played at that difficulty or higher. The required difficulty is shown as a number of highlighted pips. One pip equals difficulty 1 and so forth.

For example, if a Campaign Quest requires Difficulty 3: Elite, it can be completed during an Elite, Ominous, Nightmare, or Apocalypse campaign, but not during a Normal or Mutated campaign.

> **First Time Challenge**
> If your party is experienced with this genre of games, consider difficulty 2 (Mutated) for the first playthrough. If you seek a noticeable challenge, perhaps go with difficulty 3 or 4.

> **Punching Above Weight**
> Playing at a higher difficulty than your selected Campaign Quests require allows you to select additional Campaign Quests.

> Determine the highest minimum difficulty among your initially selected Campaign Quests. For each difficulty level you play above that value, you may select 1 additional Campaign Quest, up to a maximum of 2 additional Campaign Quests.
>
> Each additional Campaign Quest must have a minimum difficulty equal to or lower than the highest minimum difficulty among your initially selected Campaign Quests.

Difficulty 1: Normal
Play the game using the normal rules.

Difficulty 2: Mutated
Use all Normal rules.

In addition, each enemy group gains 1 random non-restricted trait when it spawns.

Difficulty 3: Elite
Use all Mutated rules.

Add four copies of the "Gruesome Wound" injury card into the injury deck.

Use only the Elite side of enemy reference cards, which is the one with the title in red.

Difficulty 4: Ominous
Use all Elite rules.

Take all "ominous" enemy trait cards and mix them into the deck of non-restricted traits.

Difficulty 5: Nightmare
Use all Ominous rules.

In addition, each enemy group gains 2 random non-restricted traits when it spawns instead of 1.

Difficulty 6: Apocalypse
Use all Nightmare rules.

In addition, at the start of each adventure, shuffle the Apocalypse Event cards into a face-down pile and draw two of those. Choose one of those two cards and apply its effects during this adventure.

Difficulty 7+: Apocalypse Plus
It is possible to push the difficulty further and further.

With each difficulty level after 6, do one additional pull of Apocalypse Cards (draw 2, choose 1) for each added difficulty level. If the pile runs out of cards during this draw, shuffle it again and continue drawing.

Playing With 3 Heroes
For solo play or groups with 3 players, it is possible to play with a party of only 3 heroes.

Treat this as if the campaign difficulty was 3 levels higher for the sake of campaign quest fulfillment.

As an adjustment, a party of 3 heroes begins each campaign either with +50 gold coins in their initial coffer, or adds a **Mythic** affix of their choice to any one starting item.

Campaign Progress
During a campaign, keep track of the following:

- Current party level
- Completed adventures and their star result
- Gold in the party coffer
- Items owned by the party
- Each hero's learned abilities
- Each hero's learned traits
- Each hero's XP and current build
- Progress toward committed Campaign Quests

You may track this on a campaign sheet, with tokens, or in any other way that works for your group.

Campaign progress belongs to the current party. Legacy unlocks belong to the players and remain available in future campaigns.

Failure

If all heroes are dead simultaneously, the party has wiped and the campaign immediately ends.

If the Questbook says the objective has failed, the adventure is lost, but not the campaign.

When an adventure is lost, the party does not gain the adventure's normal completion rewards unless the Questbook says otherwise.

In this case, the party gets to keep all rewards gained during the adventure, for example from treasure chests and they perform a town phase as usual. They also level up.

Then choose the next adventure.

Campaign End

After the party completes the 7th adventure, the campaign ends.

Resolve the following steps in order:

1. Gain any first-time boss kill rewards, if applicable.
2. Check all committed Campaign Quests.
3. Mark completed Campaign Quests on the Legacy Sheet.
4. Add any unlocked content or permanent benefits to the Legacy Sheet.
5. Record the completed campaign, including difficulty.
6. Retire the heroes.

Retired heroes are not used in future campaigns unless your group chooses to keep personal records for flavor.

A new campaign begins with a new party at level 1, but all unlocked legacy content remains available.

Class Unlocks

Some hero classes are locked at the start of the game and they cannot be chosen when creating a party.

Classes may be unlocked through Campaign Quests, first-time boss kill rewards, or other legacy rewards.

When a class is unlocked, mark it on the Legacy Sheet. From then on, that class is available during party setup in all future campaigns. Any contents from its box also become available, even if the class is not being actively played. This may include items or abilities.

Keep in mind that some class abilities are exclusive to that class. Never shuffle them into the ability deck. They are only used if someone decides to play that class.

Unlocked classes are permanent. They remain available even if a later campaign is failed or abandoned.

Permanent Benefits

Some Campaign Quests grant permanent gameplay benefits.

These benefits may improve future heroes, give the party extra resources, or modify setup.

Permanent benefits are recorded on the Legacy Sheet and apply to all future campaigns.

Numerical benefits can be gained multiple times only if the legacy process of Campaign Quests gets repeated after doing the Campaign Quest "The Ultimate Challenge". In this case their benefits stack if it is applicable. Keep in mind that the increased difficulty requirement stemming from "Ultimate Challenge" stacks higher and higher.

Examples of permanent benefits may include:

- One hero begins each campaign with +1 Health
- The party gains one free consumable during each Town Phase
- The party may choose a free Trait at the beginning of a campaign
- A Town Phase display gains additional cards

Campaign Arc Unlocks

Some campaign arcs are locked at the beginning of the game.

A locked campaign arc or any of its adventures cannot be chosen when starting a new campaign.

When a campaign arc is unlocked, mark it on the Legacy Sheet. From then on, the party may choose adventures of that arc individually when starting a new campaign.

Each campaign arc has its own adventures, enemies, bosses, and rewards, as well as its own loosely tied narrative.

> **Campaign Narratives**
> Adventures from different unlocked campaign arcs may be freely mixed and matched based on the party's preferred gameplay, rewards, and difficulty.
>
> However, when you unlock a campaign arc for the first time, it is recommended to play that arc in order from beginning to end. This allows the party to experience its full narrative, recurring characters, escalating threats, and final confrontation as one coherent journey.
>
> After that, feel free to combine unlocked adventures however you like — and ignore the story for the most part.

Hero Starting Decks

This section describes with what abilities and items every hero class begins a new campaign.

If there are not enough samples of an item to give each hero their starter item, then one hero must choose to not get this item. Instead, add its corresponding value to the initial party coffer.

Hero	Abilities	Items
Bard	Songs of Drucavia Inspired Imitation Finesse Charge	Rapier Hand Crossbow Rags
Druid	Wolf Form Bear Form Root Snare Herb Gathering	Gnarly Staff Tattered Robes Rejuvenation Elixir
Knight	Shield Bash Taunt Protect Last Resort	Chipped Sword Old Shield Chainmail
Monk	Flurry Of Blows Open Palm Strike Counter Stance	Rags Training Wraps Healing Potion Rejuvenation Elixir
Necromancer	Life Leech Bloody Sacrifice Summon Skeletons	Necrotic Wand Unholy Lamp Rags
Paladin	Shieldwall Shield Hook Martyr's Vow	Chipped Sword Old Shield Chainmail
Priest	First Aid Flash of Healing Punish Evil Infusion	Mace Tattered Robes Healing Potion
Ranger	Sniper Shot Barrage Trap	Shortbow Rags
Warrior	Advance World-Cleav. Strike Retaliate	Broken Greatsword Chainmail
Wizard	Arcane Missile Haste Telekinesis Fire Bolt Shadow Blade	Gnarly Staff Tattered Robes
Assassin	Dual Strike Follow-Up Strike Ambush Caltrops	Chipped Sword Parrying Dagger Rags
Commander	Morale Boost Setup Team Effort	Chipped Sword Banner Chainmail
Courtesan	Invisibility Comforting Words Improvised Care	Elegant Dagger Battle Fan Rags
Man-At-Arms	Aimed Shot Dwarven Combat Flowing Step	Militia Crossbow Dwarven Battleaxe Old Shield Rags
Shaman	Totem of Water Totem of Fire Totem of Air Totem of Eearth Conjure Golem	Gnarly Staff Tattered Robes
Warlock	Consume Soul Rush of Victory Blood Bolt Demon Form	Spellblade Rags
Vampire	Crimson Lunge Mist Veil Blood Feast	2 x Chipped Sword or Broken Greatsword Noble's Garments
Revenant	Grave Step Refuse the Grave Debt of Bones	Consuming Scythe Rags
Seraphim	Blazing Benedict. Wings of Censure Radiant Intercess.	Mercy Judgment Rags

Keywords

This section describes all keywords found on cards and rules in alphabetical order.

Armor - Determines the difficulty required to generate a success when making a Toughness Check.

Attack - Allows to perform an attack with any weapon currently equipped. This does not count against the limit of standard attacks per round.

Attack Of Opportunity - When a hero or minion moves and leaves adjacency to this enemy, that enemy immediately attacks the moving model

with a damage value listed as part of this keyword.

Banish - The ability has to be fully removed for the remainder of the current adventure. Once the hero reaches the town phase, they regain that ability. If the hero can choose which ability to banish, they can banish a discarded ability or one in their hand.

Big - The model occupies 2 spaces at once. It also treats all other non-big models as if they were Light (they can displace them by moving onto them).

Blast - Deals X damage to the space where the Blast was created, and all adjacent spaces that have Line of Sight to the center space. This hits all models: heroes, minions and enemies by default. By default, it is not possible to Block or Dodge a blast, but a Toughness Check is still performed.

Block - The hero blocks an incoming direct attack. They must spend 1 Stamina. They roll 4d6 against 4+, plus bonus dice from equipped shields. Each success reduces the incoming damage by one. A hero can only block up to twice per round, and they cannot combine a block with a dodge.

Combo - When a hero generates a combo, add 1 Combo token to the party's shared pool, up to a maximum of 6 tokens. Ignore any excess tokens. Before making an attack, Block, Dodge, or Spellcasting Check, a hero may spend any number of Combo tokens. Add 1d6 to that roll for each token spent. Unused Combo tokens remain available until spent or until the adventure ends.

Consume - Spend 1 Stamina to use a consumable - this ends current movement as per usual. Then handle its effects and shuffle the card back into the item deck.

Cripple - Place a Cripple token next to the affected model. It cannot voluntarily move while it has this token, but still be affected by Knockback. Cripple tokens do not stack. The token is removed at the end of the model's turn. If a model is crippled during its movement, its movement ends immediately (unless it is immune to the effect).

Daze - Place a Daze token next to the affected model. For enemies this deactivates their minor and major abilities until the end of their next turn, unless they are immune. For heroes it means they can play up to a maximum of one ability card during their next turn (out-of-turn abilities like interrupts are unaffected). Daze tokens cannot stack. They are removed when the model ends their turn.

Decay - Place X Decay tokens next to the affected model. When it ends its next turn, it loses Health based on the number of tokens. Then remove these tokens. Remember that health loss does not allow for defense or Toughness checks.

Dodge - The hero dodges an incoming direct attack. They must suffer 1 Fatigue and be able to move 1 space. If they fulfill both requirements, they roll 4d6 against 4+. Each success reduces the incoming damage by one.
Then they **must** Move 1.

Form - An ability that lets the hero enter a form provides certain benefits while the form is maintained. Only one form can be active at a time. When entering a new form, the previous one stops being active.

Heal - By default, when an ability says "Heal" it affects the model executing it, unless it specified another target. The model removes X damage tokens from itself.

Hearing Range - Hearing range is measured in walking distance from the source to the target, ignoring Line of Sight. It can go up to 8 spaces.

Immune - The model becomes immune to certain effects or status effects. It may still suffer the corresponding tokens to allow for interactions with other abilities, but it will not suffer its effects.

Interrupt - The hero immediately interrupts the game flow and executes their ability. Then resume the game flow as usual. Sometimes an Interrupt ability may have requirements as to when it can be played.

Knockback - The target has to be moved away from the source. Each space moved must increase the distance, but players can choose the exact direction if multiple spaces would increase distance. As soon as the model ends in a corner, skip any additional Knockback movement.

Light - A model that is light can be displaced by others. When other models move onto its space, the Light model has to occupy the closest available space to make way for the moving model.

Line Of Sight - A model has line of sight to another model of space when you can draw an uniniterrupted line from the center of the space to the center of the target space. It may not overlap with a red line or a white wall. If it exactly crosses a corner of such a line or wall, line of sight is still valid.

Melee Attack - An ability with this keyword allows the hero to immediately execute an attack. It has to be an attack with a melee weapon (one that does not have a "Range" keyword on it). This does not count against the limit of standard attacks for the round.

Move - The model immediately gains X movement points that it can move to move around. Heroes can use such movement points to also trade or re-equip items.

Nimble - A model that is nimble is allowed to move over the spaces occupied by opposing forces. So an enemy may move over heroes / minions, or a hero / minion may move over enemies.

Non-Lethal Attacks - An enemy with this keyword does not attack the health of a hero. Their damage instead causes Fatigue on a 1:1 basis. The hero can defend as per usual. Since minions cannot suffer Fatigue, they suffer regular damage from a Non-Lethal Attack instead. Non-lethal attacks can still cause injuries. If a non-lethal attack would cause more Fatigue than the hero can suffer, the surplus amount is ignored.

Offense - Offense describes the number of dice rolled with an attack.

Ranged Attack - An ability with this keyword allows the hero to immediately execute an attack. It has to be an attack with a ranged weapon (one that has a "Range" keyword on it). This does not count against the limit of standard attacks for the round.

Reach - A melee attack with this keyword can attack over a range of 2 spaces, instead of being limited to adjacent targets.

Regain - When this keyword is evoked, the hero may regain a previously discarded ability. If it doesn't specify further, the hero may choose which ability to regain. Sometimes a dice option on an ability can allow that ability to be regained right after its use.

Repeat - The entire ability may be repeated without having to pay its base costs. It may choose different targets unless stated otherwise. If a spellcasting ability is repeated, the entire spellcasting roll must be made for the new execution, and individually trigger dice options again. **An ability that is repeated cannot trigger another repeat** - infinite chains are not possible.

Reroll - This keyword generates X rerolls for the targeted hero. Track these with a die or with tokens. Each hero can store up to 6 rerolls and these are only lost when the adventure ends, or when spent. When a hero makes any dice roll, they can spend rerolls to reroll individual dice. They can spend their rerolls one by one until they are happy with their result or run out of rerolls. Keep in mind that an individual die can only be re-rolled once per check, and the second result must be kept.
Minions can use rerolls if they are granted during a roll, but they cannot store them persistently.

Resilient - An enemy that is resilient can never suffer more than X damage with each attack or spell that targets it. Surplus damage is ignored.

Rest - The hero in question regenerates X fatigue. Simply discard the fatigue token(s).

Retreat - An enemy with this keyword will move away after performing its default attack. It moves X spaces in an attempt to maximize the walking distance to the targeted hero. If it was cornered before, it may even move behind the hero and then further away. If there is no means to maximize the distance to the target, Retreat is skipped. If multiple locations fulfill the requirement, the party chooses.

Rush - When a hero executes a Rush ability, they first execute that ability as if it was an Interrupt. Then that hero makes their entire turn, interrupting the gameflow. Their position on the initiative track remains unchanged, and the order of enemy activation does not alter.
If the hero already had their turn in this round, they do not take another full turn - in this case they only get execute that ability as an Interrupt.
When enemies have Rush, they immediately execute their turn, but after Stamina checks and determining the initiative order.
Heroes can interject by playing their own Rush ability to act before them.

Sacrifice - The hero has to lose X health. This can absolutely kill a hero.

Spellcasting - Spellcasting checks are required to unfold the effects of a spell. By default, a hero rolls 4d6 against 4+. They add bonus dice from any traits or equipped items. Their successes must meet the target number of the spellcasting check. Dice used to trigger dice options cannot count as successes.

Stealth - A model in Stealth cannot be targeted directly. Stealthed heroes and minions are also ignored during enemy AI target prioritization. However, a model with lower (=faster) Initiative than the stealthed model ignores these restrictions.
A stealthed model is also considered **Light**. If the same model displaces it twice consecutively, Stealth ends.
Stealth lasts indefinitely until broken. It ends when the model performs an attack or opens a door. For heroes, it also ends when performing any action other than Move or Meditate. Reactions such as Block, Dodge, or Assist do not break Stealth.

Stun - A stunned enemy or minion does not perform their default attack, but still moves or executes abilities if applicable. After they skipped an attack, remove all Stun tokens. Enemies still count as if they had attacked towards counting their group's attack limit.
A stunned hero rolls only half their dice during the next round's Stamina check, round up. Once they suffered this disadvantage, that hero removes all Stun tokens.

Surge - The targeted hero immediately gains X Stamina, but cannot exceed their maximum - the maximum is based on their hero card's maximum minus current Fatigue. By default, Surge only affects the hero executing the ability unless it explicitly targets another hero.

Targets - This dice option allows to choose one additional target to be affected by the ability. That new target must meet the same targeting requirements as the initial ones. All dice options that were triggered also affect the additional targets.

Taunt - Place a taunt token next to the target and remember who evoked it. The next time that enemy activates and chooses a target, it ignores its AI card's instructions and picks the taunting hero instead. If the taunting hero cannot be reached, the taunt is ignored. After that enemy ends its turn, remove all Taunt tokens.
Should an enemy be taunted by more than one hero, use its AI card instructions but only consider heroes who taunted this enemy.

Tough - If an enemy with this keyword gets attacked, the attacking hero has to re-roll the X highest dice of their roll. Keep in mind that a rerolled die cannot be rerolled again. Tough does not affect spellcasting checks.

Treat - The hero in question may remove X injuries. They can choose which injuries to remove. Discard the card and put it on the bottom of the injury deck.

Weave - Whenever a hero gains Weave, they store 1 Weave token, up to a maximum of 2 per hero. When making a spellcasting roll, a hero may spend Weave tokens to add +1d8 per token spent, even after rolling. Weave generated during an action may be spent on that same action.

Closing Words

This rule book represents an early edition of the game that is still in testing and iteration.
Things may change, and the rule book will receive proper depictions and illustrations at a later point in time.

We hope you enjoy Dire Beginnings!